

LISTENING

#30

1 – Listen to a science reporter interviewing an expert about how canine genetics influence dog intelligence and behavior. Pay attention to the types of intelligence described and why dogs have become so responsive to human communication.

Dog Intelligence

1 - What does the expert say is the first type of canine intelligence?

2 - According to the expert, what does adaptive intelligence refer to?

- a) What the dog was bred to do
- b) What the dog can learn for itself
- c) How well the dog follows human cues

3 - Which group of dogs is described as the oldest breeds?

- a) Retrievers
- b) Hounds
- c) Terriers

4 - Why does the expert say hounds make “lousy students”?

- a) They are too energetic
- b) They were bred to hunt independently
- c) They dislike humans

5 - What characteristic makes retrievers good students?

- a) They are naturally aggressive
- b) They wait for human cues and follow instructions
- c) They avoid interacting with humans

6 - How long does the expert say humans have been selectively shaping dog behavior?

7 - What simple task does the expert use to illustrate dogs’ ability to read human signals?

8 - How does a wolf typically react when a human points at something?

- a) It looks where the person is pointing
- b) It ignores the gesture
- c) It looks at the person’s hand

Canine Cognition & Human–Dog Interaction

Researchers have long been fascinated by the unusual bond between humans and dogs. While many species have been domesticated for practical purposes, dogs occupy a special category: they have developed cognitive skills that allow them to understand human communication in ways few other animals can. According to recent research, this ability may be deeply rooted in both genetics and shared evolutionary history.

Scientists studying dog cognition have found that domestication did far more than shape physical appearance. Over thousands of years, humans consistently selected animals that were cooperative, attentive, and responsive to social signals. As a result, modern dogs excel at interpreting gestures such as pointing, directing, and eye movements. These skills give them a remarkable advantage in working roles, from guiding and herding to assisting people with disabilities.

Another important factor is emotional attunement. Studies show that dogs can detect subtle changes in human facial expressions and vocal tones, allowing them to react to stress, excitement, or frustration. This sensitivity helps explain why dogs form such strong bonds with families and thrive in household environments. Some researchers argue that this mutual understanding has created a feedback loop: the more dogs learned to read humans, the more humans relied on dogs for support and companionship.

Despite this, not all breeds approach communication in the same way. Dogs historically bred for independent work, such as tracking or guarding, may be less responsive to training or cooperative tasks. Others, like retrievers and shepherding breeds, tend to excel in structured learning. Still, scientists emphasize that individual variation plays a major role, and training quality can significantly influence a dog's behavior.

Understanding these differences, researchers say, helps explain why the human–dog relationship remains one of the most enduring partnerships in the animal kingdom.

Retrieved from: <https://www.theguardian.com/science/2024/feb/12/how-dogs-became-so-smart>

Comprehension Questions

1. According to the article, what advantage do modern dogs have when interpreting human behavior?

2. What emotional ability helps dogs build strong bonds with humans?

3. Why might some breeds be less responsive to structured training?

4. What role did selective breeding play in shaping how dogs interact with humans?

5. How does emotional attunement influence the relationship between humans and dogs?
